

2.5 Global Systems and Global Governance

This is a **compulsory** section of AQA 7037 Component 2 (Human geography), assessed in Section A of Paper 2 alongside Changing Places and one optional topic. Every student sits it. The two halves of the title matter: *global systems* are the flows and connections that bind places together; *global governance* is the attempt to regulate them. AQA's emphasis falls on international trade and access to markets, and on the governance of the global commons — with **Antarctica** as the named case study.

1. Globalisation: Dimensions and Drivers

Globalisation: The process by which national economies, societies and cultures become increasingly integrated through flows of capital, labour, products, services and information, producing a growing interdependence between places. It is not new — trade networks are ancient — but its *speed, depth and reach* since the 1980s are unprecedented.

Dimensions of Globalisation

Flow	What moves	Scale (dated evidence)
Capital	Foreign direct investment, portfolio investment, aid, remittances, profit repatriation	Global FDI rose 6% to \$1.6 trillion in 2025, ending two years of decline; the top 20 host economies took more than 80% of it (UNCTAD, World Investment Report 2026)
Labour	Economic migrants, skilled professionals, refugees, seasonal workers	304 million international migrants in 2024 — 3.7% of world population, up from 77 million in 1960 (UN DESA)
Products	Raw materials, components, finished manufactured goods	World merchandise trade volume rose 4.5% year-on-year over the first nine months of 2025, with the dollar

		value up 6.5% to a record (WTO, January 2026)
Services	Finance, insurance, tourism, back-office and call-centre work, software	Services have grown faster than goods trade for most of the last two decades; digitally delivered services are the fastest-growing component
Information	Data, media, ideas, technology, culture	Around two-thirds of humanity is online, but the ITU estimated roughly 2.6 billion people were still unconnected in 2024

Global marketing: Treating the world as a single market and selling a standardised product with a standardised brand identity, adjusted only lightly for local taste ("glocalisation"). McDonald's sells the same core menu worldwide but adds the McSpicy Paneer in India; Coca-Cola runs globally recognisable branding with locally adapted advertising. It works because global media and migration have produced converging consumer expectations.

Factors Driving Globalisation

Factor	How it enables globalisation
Transport technology	Containerisation (from 1956) cut the cost and time of handling cargo dramatically and made complex international supply chains viable. Bulk carriers, wide-body jets and refrigerated shipping allow perishable goods to move globally.
Communications and ICT	Submarine fibre-optic cables carry the overwhelming majority of international data. Satellite, mobile networks and cloud computing allow a firm to coordinate design, manufacture and sales across time zones in real time.
Financial systems	Deregulation from the 1980s, electronic trading and 24-hour markets in London, New York, Tokyo and Singapore allow capital to move almost instantly. Offshore financial centres let firms shift profits across borders.
Management and information systems	Just-in-time production, global logistics software and standardised containers and protocols allow a single product to be assembled from components made in dozens of countries.

Security and legal frameworks	Enforceable contracts, intellectual property law, investor protection treaties and predictable customs procedures make cross-border investment tolerable in risk terms.
Trade agreements	GATT (1947) and then the WTO (1995) cut average tariffs sharply; regional blocs and bilateral deals removed further barriers. The WTO now has 166 members covering about 98% of world trade.

2. Global Systems and Interdependence

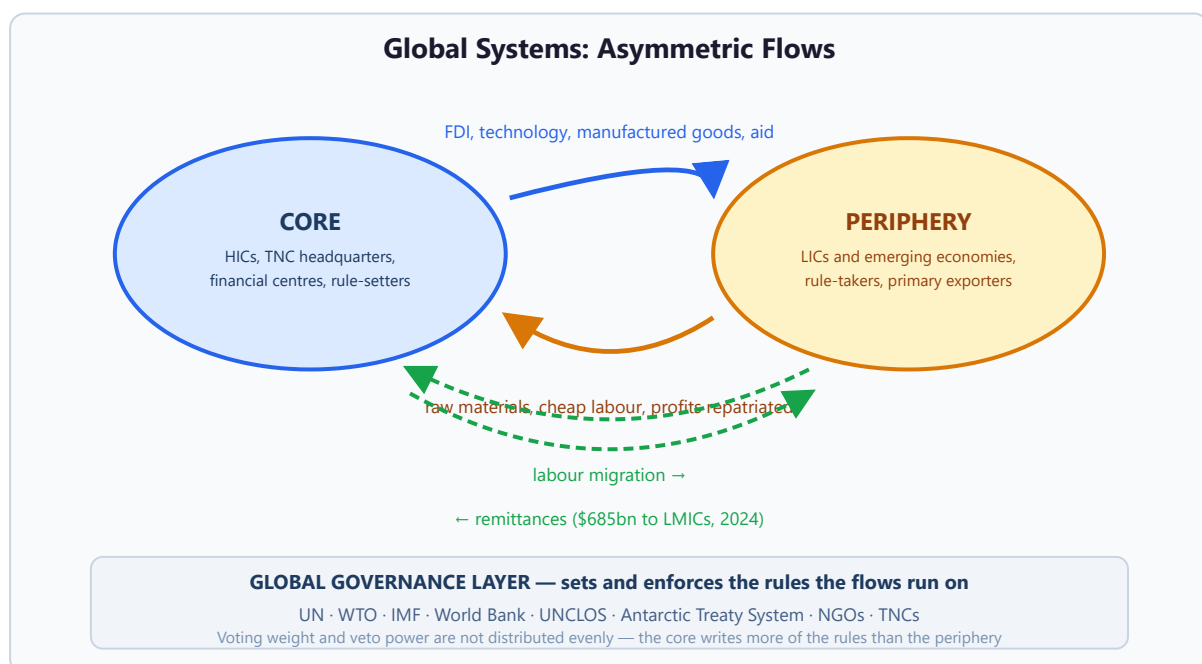
Interdependence: A relationship of mutual dependence between places, in which what happens in one has consequences for the other. It has economic, political, social and environmental dimensions, and it is almost never symmetrical — one partner usually needs the other more.

Dimension	Example of interdependence
Economic	A shortage of semiconductors made in Taiwan halts car assembly lines in Germany, Japan and the United States. European gas markets repriced across the whole continent after Russian pipeline supply was cut from 2022.
Political	Membership of the EU, NATO or ASEAN binds states into shared rules and obligations. Sanctions regimes depend on other states enforcing them.
Social	Diaspora communities maintain remittance flows, cultural ties and political influence. Remittances to low- and middle-income countries reached an estimated \$685 billion in 2024 (World Bank) — larger than either FDI or official development assistance to those countries.
Environmental	Greenhouse gases emitted anywhere warm everywhere. Amazon deforestation alters rainfall in South America and carbon storage globally. Fishing fleets from distant states deplete stocks in others' waters.

Unequal Flows and Unequal Power

AQA asks you to judge whether unequal flows *promote* stability, growth and development, or *cause* inequality, conflict and injustice. The honest answer is that the same flow usually does both, and which effect dominates depends on the power of the place receiving it.

- **Flows of money:** FDI brings capital, technology and jobs — but profits are often repatriated, and investment is highly concentrated. In 2025 developing economies as a group saw FDI grow only 2%, to \$901 billion, while inflows to developed economies rose 11%; developing Asia alone took \$644 billion of the developing-country total, leaving most of sub-Saharan Africa largely bypassed (UNCTAD, 2026).
- **Flows of people:** migration fills labour shortages in destination countries and generates remittances that reduce poverty at source — but it can also strip origin countries of skilled workers (the "brain drain" of health professionals from sub-Saharan Africa to the UK and Gulf states) and produce political backlash in destinations.
- **Flows of ideas and technology:** mobile banking transformed financial inclusion in East Africa; global scientific collaboration produced COVID-19 vaccines within a year. But intellectual property rules concentrate the returns in a handful of firms and countries, and vaccine distribution in 2021 showed how sharply access can be rationed by wealth.
- **Unequal power relations:** a small number of states set the rules. The five permanent members of the UN Security Council hold a veto. Voting power at the IMF and World Bank is weighted by financial contribution, giving the United States an effective veto over decisions requiring an 85% majority. The dollar's role as the dominant reserve and trade-settlement currency gives the US the ability to impose secondary sanctions with global effect.



Exam Tip: The command words in this topic are usually *assess*, *evaluate* or *to what extent*, and the best answers argue about *whom the system works for*. A 20-mark answer that describes globalisation without ever naming a winner and a loser is capped low. Practise a sentence structure like: "For X, the flow produced Y; for Z, the same flow produced W — the difference is explained by A."

3. International Trade and Access to Markets

Comparative advantage: Ricardo's argument that countries gain from specialising in what they produce at the lowest *opportunity cost* and trading for the rest, even if one country is absolutely better at producing everything. It is the theoretical case for free trade — but it assumes capital and labour are immobile, that full employment exists, and that terms of trade are fair, none of which reliably holds.

Patterns and Trends in World Trade

- **Volume:** world merchandise trade has grown far faster than world output since 1950. Global merchandise imports and exports combined were roughly four times their 2000 value by 2025.
- **Composition:** the share of manufactures has risen and the share of primary commodities has fallen, though commodity *prices* remain highly volatile. Trade in services and in digitally delivered services is the fastest-growing segment.
- **Direction:** the centre of gravity has shifted east. China became the world's largest merchandise exporter; intra-Asian trade is now one of the largest flows on the planet. Much world trade is *intra-industry* (components crossing borders repeatedly within a supply chain) and *intra-firm* (between subsidiaries of the same TNC).
- **Recent turbulence:** since 2018 tariff increases, export controls on strategic technologies, and "friend-shoring" of supply chains have partly reversed the long liberalisation. The WTO's own reporting describes rising trade-restrictive measures alongside record trade values — growth and fragmentation at the same time.

Differential Access to Markets

Barrier	Effect on less developed exporters
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Tariffs	Taxes on imports raise the price of foreign goods. Average tariffs have fallen, but peaks remain on precisely the goods poorer countries export — agriculture, textiles, clothing.
Tariff escalation	Tariffs rise with the degree of processing: raw cocoa beans face low or zero duty, cocoa butter more, finished chocolate more still. This actively discourages value-adding in producer countries and locks them into exporting raw commodities.
Quotas and non-tariff barriers	Volume limits, plus standards on food safety, packaging, labelling and sustainability that are costly for small producers to certify against.
Subsidies	Domestic support to farmers in the EU and US allows producers to undercut unsubsidised competitors in third markets.
Trade blocs	Members enjoy preferential access to each other but erect a common external tariff, diverting trade away from more efficient non-members.
Infrastructure and geography	Landlocked states, poor ports, unreliable power and weak logistics raise the delivered cost of exports regardless of production efficiency.

Trade blocs: Groups of states that agree preferential trading terms. They range from free trade areas (no internal tariffs — USMCA, AfCFTA) through customs unions (a common external tariff) to common markets and economic unions with free movement of labour and capital and a shared currency (the EU's 27 members, 20 of them in the eurozone). ASEAN admitted **Timor-Leste as its 11th member on 26 October 2025**. The CPTPP, which the **UK joined in December 2024**, shows blocs are no longer necessarily regional.

Exam Tip: Tariff escalation is one of the sharpest pieces of evidence you can deploy, because it shows that unequal access is designed rather than accidental. If you can explain why Ghana exports beans rather than chocolate bars, you have answered most of what AQA asks about access to markets.

4. Transnational Corporations

Transnational corporation (TNC): A firm that owns or controls production, service or research operations in more than one country. TNCs are the main architects of global production networks: they decide where research, manufacture, assembly and sales take place, and their internal transfers account for a substantial share of world trade.

Feature	Explanation
Spatial organisation	Headquarters and R&D in HICs (access to skills, finance, IP protection); manufacturing and assembly in lower-cost economies; regional sales and service divisions near markets. The "global shift" of manufacturing from the industrial West to East and South-East Asia from the 1970s onwards.
Linkages	Backward linkages to component suppliers and raw materials; forward linkages to distributors and retailers. Where these develop locally, a multiplier effect follows; where the TNC imports everything, the host gains only wages.
Trading patterns	Much of a TNC's "international trade" is intra-firm — components moving between its own subsidiaries. Transfer pricing (setting the internal price of those transfers) can shift declared profit into low-tax jurisdictions, reducing tax paid in the countries where production and sales actually happen.
Marketing	Global brand identity plus localised campaigns; enormous advertising spend creates brand value that is itself a barrier to entry for competitors.

Case Study: Apple — A Specified TNC and Its Global Production Network

AQA requires detailed reference to one named TNC. Apple is useful because its production network is unusually well documented. **Spatial organisation:** design, software and marketing are concentrated at its Cupertino, California headquarters; its most advanced processors are fabricated by TSMC in Taiwan; display, camera and memory components come from suppliers in South Korea, Japan and China; final assembly is carried out by contract manufacturers — principally Foxconn, Pegatron and Tata Electronics — at very large sites in China, India and Vietnam. Apple's published supplier list covers around 200 companies representing about 98% of its direct spend on materials, manufacturing and assembly, with sites in dozens of countries. **Linkages and impacts on hosts:** Foxconn's Zhengzhou campus in Henan, China, employs well over 100,000 workers in peak production season and has reshaped the city's economy and infrastructure, drawing large-scale

internal migration from rural Henan. Since 2020 Apple has diversified assembly towards India and Vietnam to reduce exposure to tariffs, pandemic disruption and geopolitical risk; analysts estimated India could account for roughly 15–20% of iPhone assembly by the end of 2025, and Tata Electronics' acquisition of Wistron's Indian plant put a domestic Indian firm inside the network for the first time.

Costs and criticism: investigations by NGOs and journalists have repeatedly raised excessive overtime, student-intern labour and mental health concerns at assembly sites; Apple publishes annual supplier responsibility audits in response. On tax, the European Commission ruled in 2016 that Ireland had granted Apple unlawful state aid, and in **September 2024 the Court of Justice of the European Union upheld that decision**, requiring Apple to pay Ireland around €13 billion plus interest — a landmark illustration of a governance body pushing back against transfer pricing.

Evaluation: Apple demonstrates the core paradox of TNCs. It transfers technology, creates hundreds of thousands of jobs and generates enormous supplier ecosystems; it also captures the overwhelming majority of the value chain's profit at the design and brand end, leaves assembly on thin margins, and can relocate faster than host communities can adapt.

5. World Trade in a Food Commodity: Cocoa

AQA requires study of world trade in at least one food commodity or one manufactured product. Cocoa is the clearest demonstration of how the structure of a commodity chain, rather than the productivity of the farmer, determines who gets paid.

Case Study: The Global Cocoa Trade

The geography: Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana together supply roughly 60% of the world's cocoa beans, grown mainly by smallholders on farms of a few hectares. Processing into cocoa butter and liquor, and manufacture into confectionery, take place overwhelmingly in Europe and North America. The Netherlands is one of the world's largest cocoa *processors* despite growing none of it.

The value chain: historically, cocoa farmers have received only a small fraction of the retail price of a chocolate bar, while processors, brand manufacturers and retailers capture most of it. **Tariff escalation** entrenches this: duties rise with each stage of processing, so it is cheaper to ship beans to Europe than to make chocolate in Abidjan.

Price volatility: world cocoa prices reached an all-time high of around \$12,500 per tonne in December 2024, driven by disease, ageing trees and poor harvests in West Africa, then fell back below roughly \$6,000 per tonne through 2025–26. That swing shows both sides of commodity dependence: producer countries saw record export earnings and then a sharp reversal. Côte d'Ivoire

set a record main-crop farmgate price of about 4,800 CFA francs per kilogram in October 2025, then cut the mid-crop farmgate price sharply for 2025/26 as world prices fell — farmers carry the volatility, not the manufacturers.

Governance responses: Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana jointly introduced a Living Income Differential in 2019, a fixed premium on top of the world price. Fairtrade sets a floor: from **1 October 2026** its Minimum Price for conventional cocoa rises 45% to \$3,500 per tonne (€3,200 in Côte d'Ivoire) and the Fairtrade Premium rises to \$275 per tonne. The EU Deforestation Regulation requires importers to prove cocoa was not grown on recently deforested land — environmentally valuable, but a compliance cost that falls hardest on the smallest farmers, which is exactly the "governance can exacerbate inequality" point AQA wants you to be able to argue.

6. Global Governance: Norms, Laws and Institutions

Global governance: The rules, norms, laws and institutions through which international affairs are regulated in the absence of a world government. It is not the same as government: there is no global authority with coercive power over sovereign states. Compliance rests on treaty obligation, reciprocity, reputation and, sometimes, sanction.

The Post-1945 Architecture

Institution	Founded	Role and criticism
United Nations	1945; 193 member states	Peace and security, development, human rights, humanitarian relief; specialised agencies including UNEP, WHO, UNHCR and UNESCO. <i>Criticism:</i> the Security Council's five permanent members each hold a veto, which reflects the power balance of 1945 and can paralyse action.
IMF	1944 (Bretton Woods)	Lends to states in balance-of-payments crisis and monitors macroeconomic stability. <i>Criticism:</i> structural adjustment conditions imposed in the 1980s–90s required cuts to public spending and rapid liberalisation, with severe social costs; voting is weighted by quota, giving the US an effective veto over decisions needing an 85% majority.

World Bank	1944	Finances development projects and poverty reduction. <i>Criticism:</i> large infrastructure projects have displaced communities; the presidency has by convention always gone to an American.
WTO	1995 (from GATT, 1947); 166 members	Negotiates trade rules and adjudicates disputes. <i>Criticism:</i> decision-making by consensus among 166 members has stalled the Doha round; its Appellate Body has been paralysed since December 2019 because the US has blocked appointments, so appealed rulings can fall into a legal void. Members have worked around this with the Multi-Party Interim Appeal Arbitration Arrangement (MPIA) , which by 2026 had grown to 61 participating members and is explicitly temporary pending reform.
Regional and issue-based bodies	Various	The EU, African Union, ASEAN; the IPCC for climate science; the International Seabed Authority for the deep ocean; CCAMLR for Southern Ocean fisheries. Increasingly the real work of governance happens at this level.

Scales of Governance

AQA explicitly wants you to see that "interactions between the local, regional, national, international and global scales are fundamental to understanding global governance." A global agreement is worthless without national legislation to implement it, regional bodies to coordinate it and local enforcement to make it real. The Paris Agreement sets a global temperature goal; nationally determined contributions translate it into national policy; city networks and local planning authorities deliver much of the actual emissions reduction. Conversely, a single national government can stall a global process, as the blocking of WTO Appellate Body appointments shows.

Exam Tip: When you criticise an institution, criticise its *mechanism*, not just its outcomes. "The UN is ineffective" earns little. "The Security Council operates by unanimity among its five permanent members, so any measure affecting the interests of one of them can be blocked regardless of the majority view" earns a great deal more, because it explains *why* the outcome follows.

7. The Global Commons

Global commons: Resource domains that lie outside the political reach of any single state and to which all nations have a legal right of access. Four are conventionally recognised: the **high seas**, the **atmosphere**, **Antarctica** and **outer space**. Because no one owns them, no one has an automatic incentive to conserve them — and because everyone has a right to their benefits, their protection has to be negotiated rather than imposed.

Garrett Hardin's 1968 essay "The Tragedy of the Commons" argued that individually rational use of a shared resource leads to collective ruin: each fishing fleet gains the full value of an extra catch while the cost of depletion is shared by all. Elinor Ostrom's later work, for which she won the Nobel Prize in Economics in 2009, showed that communities frequently *do* manage commons sustainably when they can define boundaries, monitor use, and impose graduated sanctions on rule-breakers. That is a more useful frame for A-level answers: the question is not whether commons are doomed, but whether the governance arrangements have the three things Ostrom identified — clear rules, monitoring and enforcement.

The rights-and-responsibilities tension: AQA's phrasing is careful — "the rights of all to the benefits of the global commons" must be reconciled with "the need to protect the global commons". A developing state can reasonably argue that restricting its access to Antarctic fisheries or deep-sea minerals locks in an advantage for the wealthy states that exploited those resources first. Sustainable development and conservation are not automatically the same thing, and the strongest answers hold that tension rather than resolving it too neatly.

8. Governance of the Oceans

The ocean covers about 71% of the planet and the high seas — the water column beyond national jurisdiction — make up roughly two-thirds of it. They are the largest of the global commons and, until very recently, the least governed.

UNCLOS — the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea: Adopted in 1982 and in force since 1994, often called "the constitution for the oceans". It had **172 States Parties** as of 2026 (including the European Union). The **United States has still not ratified it**, objecting historically to the deep-seabed mining provisions, although it treats most of the rest as customary international law.

Zone	Extent from baseline	Rights
Territorial sea	12 nautical miles	Full sovereignty, subject to innocent passage for foreign vessels
Contiguous zone	24 nautical miles	Enforcement of customs, immigration, sanitary and fiscal law
Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)	200 nautical miles	Sovereign rights over living and non-living resources, and over energy generation
Continental shelf	200 nm, extendable to 350 nm on geological evidence	Rights to seabed and subsoil resources
High seas	Beyond national jurisdiction	Freedom of navigation, overflight, fishing, cable-laying and scientific research for all states
"The Area" (deep seabed)	Beyond national jurisdiction	Declared the common heritage of mankind ; minerals administered by the International Seabed Authority, with benefits to be shared

The Gap UNCLOS Left, and How It Was Closed

UNCLOS gave states rights over the high seas but created no mechanism for establishing protected areas there, no requirement for environmental impact assessment of high-seas activity, and no rules on sharing the benefits of marine genetic resources. Fisheries management was left to a patchwork of regional bodies with uneven coverage. The result was a commons with rights but very few responsibilities.

Case Study: The High Seas Treaty (BBNJ Agreement) — New Governance in Force

The Agreement on Marine Biodiversity of Areas Beyond National Jurisdiction was adopted in June 2023 after almost two decades of negotiation. It reached its threshold of 60 ratifications on 19 September 2025 and **entered into force on 17 January 2026**. By September 2026 it had around 94 ratifying parties and 145 signatories. **What it does:** it creates a legal route to establish marine protected areas on the high seas for the first time; requires environmental impact assessments for planned high-seas activities; sets rules for sharing the benefits of marine genetic resources

(important for pharmaceutical bioprospecting); and provides for capacity-building and technology transfer to developing states. **Why it matters:** the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework agreed in December 2022 commits states to protecting 30% of land and ocean by 2030, and that target was effectively unreachable without a mechanism for the two-thirds of the ocean lying beyond national jurisdiction. **Limits:** the treaty binds only its parties; several major fishing and shipping states have not yet ratified; existing regional fisheries bodies and the International Seabed Authority retain their mandates, so overlapping competence and enforcement on a vast, remote area remain unresolved. It is a textbook example of governance catching up with a commons — decades late, and with implementation still to prove.

Exam Tip: The High Seas Treaty is recent enough that most candidates will not have it. Use it precisely — adopted 2023, 60th ratification September 2025, in force 17 January 2026 — and use it to make an argument, not just to show off a date. It is strong evidence both that global governance *can* deliver (a binding instrument for the largest commons) and that it is slow and incomplete (twenty years of negotiation, enforcement unproven).

9. Antarctica as a Global Common

The Contemporary Geography of Antarctica

- **Physical:** around 14 million km², about 98% covered by ice averaging close to 2 km thick and holding roughly 60–70% of the world's freshwater. The lowest natural air temperature ever reliably recorded at the surface was –89.2°C at Vostok in 1983. Katabatic winds drain off the ice dome at destructive speeds; the interior is a polar desert with very low precipitation.
- **The Southern Ocean**, as far north as the **Antarctic Convergence** (where cold Antarctic surface water sinks beneath warmer sub-Antarctic water), is treated as part of the region. The Antarctic Circumpolar Current isolates it thermally and is the largest ocean current on Earth.
- **Ecology:** a short, krill-dependent food web. Antarctic krill are the keystone species, supporting baleen whales, seals, penguins, fish and seabirds. Terrestrial life is sparse — two flowering plant species, mosses, lichens and invertebrates.
- **Human presence:** no indigenous or permanent population. Roughly 70 research stations operated by around 30 countries, with a summer population in the low thousands falling to around 1,000 in winter.

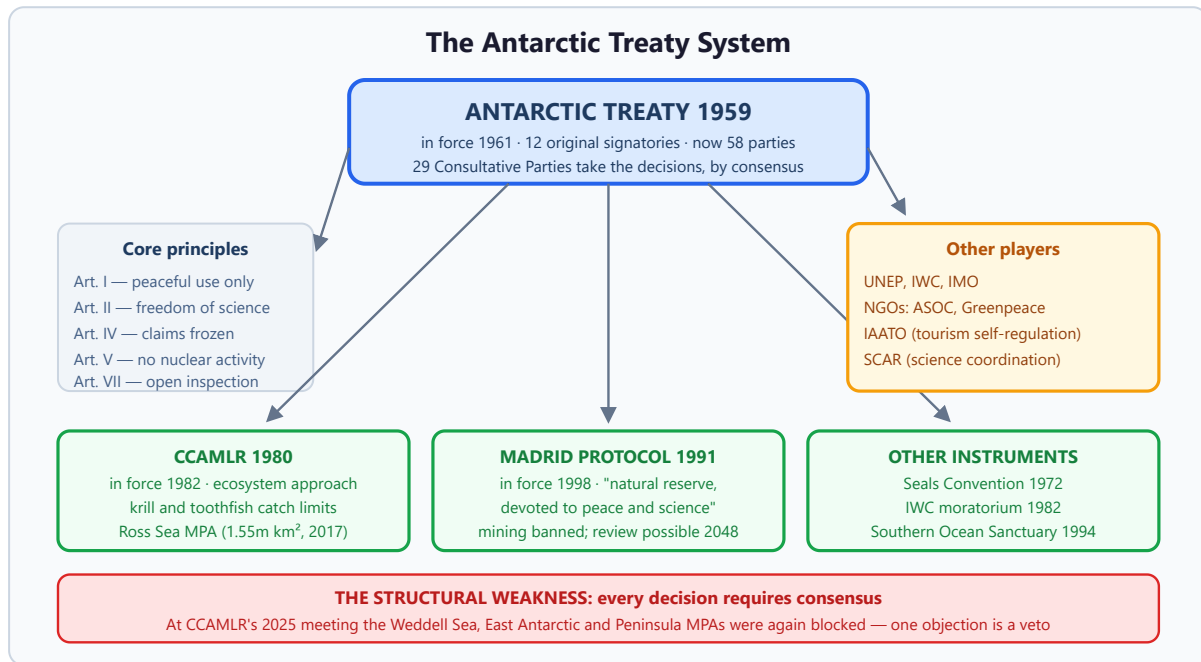
Threats to Antarctica

Threat	Evidence and mechanism
Climate change	The Antarctic Peninsula is one of the fastest-warming regions in the Southern Hemisphere. Ice shelves that buttress grounded ice have collapsed — Larsen B disintegrated in 2002 and the glaciers behind it accelerated up to eightfold. Antarctic sea-ice extent, stable for decades, has hit repeated record lows since 2016. The Thwaites and Pine Island glaciers in West Antarctica are losing mass rapidly and carry substantial sea-level implications. Ocean acidification threatens the shell-forming organisms at the base of the food web.
Fishing	Krill and Patagonian/Antarctic toothfish are the commercially targeted species. The krill fishery is concentrated in Area 48 around the Antarctic Peninsula — exactly where penguin and seal colonies feed. The precautionary 620,000-tonne trigger limit for Area 48 was reached for the first time in the 2025 season , forcing an in-season closure of the fishery (CCAMLR Fishery Report 2025). Illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing for toothfish remains difficult to police across such a vast area.
Whaling	Industrial whaling in the twentieth century removed an estimated 1.5 million whales from Southern Ocean waters and drove blue whales to about 1% of their pre-whaling abundance. The IWC moratorium on commercial whaling was adopted in 1982 and took effect from the 1985/86 season; the Southern Ocean Whale Sanctuary followed in 1994. Recovery is real but slow — humpback populations have rebounded strongly, blue whales far less so. Japan withdrew from the IWC in 2019 and resumed commercial whaling within its own EEZ, while Norway and Iceland continue under objection or reservation.
Mineral resources	Coal, iron ore and offshore hydrocarbons are known or suspected, and Russian seismic surveys in the Weddell Sea reported in 2024 revived concern about prospecting under the cover of "scientific research". No commercial extraction is permitted — but the ban is a treaty provision, not a physical impossibility.
Tourism	IAATO recorded 118,491 visitors in the 2024–25 season , down slightly from 122,072 in 2023–24 but roughly triple the numbers of a decade earlier. Impacts include disturbance at landing sites, trampling of fragile moss beds, introduction of non-native species on boots and cargo, fuel spills and black carbon deposition on snow, which lowers albedo.

Scientific research

Stations generate waste, sewage, fuel spills and local habitat disturbance, and the footprint of infrastructure is concentrated in the small ice-free areas that are also the most biologically valuable. Research is also the primary justification for national presence, so the line between science and geopolitics is not always clean.

The Governance of Antarctica



Instrument	Purpose, scope and enforcement
The Antarctic Treaty (1959)	Signed by 12 states active during the International Geophysical Year, in force from 1961; now 58 parties, of which 29 are Consultative Parties entitled to take decisions. Applies south of 60°S. Reserves Antarctica for peaceful purposes, guarantees freedom of scientific investigation and exchange of data, prohibits nuclear explosions and radioactive waste disposal, and — crucially — Article IV freezes all territorial claims , neither recognising nor denying the seven existing claims and barring new ones. <i>Enforcement:</i> Article VII gives every Consultative Party the right to inspect any station, installation or ship at any time, with no advance notice. This open-inspection regime is unusually strong for an international treaty and has been used repeatedly.
CCAMLR (1980, in force 1982)	The Convention on the Conservation of Antarctic Marine Living Resources governs fishing in the Southern Ocean using an <i>ecosystem approach</i> : catch limits are set to protect dependent and related species, not just the target stock. It agreed the Ross Sea region

	MPA in 2016 (in force 1 December 2017), at 1.55 million km² the largest marine protected area in the world, of which about 72% is fully no-take, for an initial 35-year term. <i>Weakness:</i> it decides by consensus. Proposals for further MPAs in the Weddell Sea, East Antarctica and around the Antarctic Peninsula have been tabled repeatedly and blocked, most recently at the 44th meeting in Hobart in October 2025, principally by Russia and China.
Madrid Protocol (1991, in force 1998)	The Protocol on Environmental Protection designates Antarctica "a natural reserve, devoted to peace and science". Article 7 prohibits any activity relating to mineral resources other than scientific research. Six annexes cover environmental impact assessment, conservation of flora and fauna, waste disposal, marine pollution, protected areas and liability. <i>The 2048 question:</i> the Protocol has no expiry date, but from 2048 (50 years after entry into force) any Consultative Party may request a review conference. Modifying the mining ban before then requires unanimity among the Consultative Parties, and any change would still need ratification by a large majority — so "the ban expires in 2048" is a common and marks-losing misconception.
UN agencies and the IWC	UNEP coordinates environmental monitoring and reporting; the IMO's Polar Code regulates shipping safety and pollution in polar waters; the International Whaling Commission adopted the commercial whaling moratorium in 1982 and designated the Southern Ocean Whale Sanctuary in 1994. <i>Weakness:</i> states may lodge objections or reservations, and Japan simply left the IWC in 2019 — membership of these bodies is voluntary.
NGOs	The Antarctic and Southern Ocean Coalition (ASOC) is the only NGO with formal observer status at Antarctic Treaty meetings and at CCAMLR, where it monitors compliance and lobbies for MPAs. Greenpeace's 1980s "World Park Antarctica" campaign, including a base at Cape Evans used to inspect national stations, is widely credited with helping to defeat the proposed CRAMRA minerals convention and secure the Madrid Protocol instead — a rare, well-documented case of NGO pressure changing a treaty outcome. IAATO, the tour operators' association, imposes landing limits and biosecurity rules on its members — effective self-regulation, but voluntary and binding only on members.

Case Study: Assessing Antarctic Governance — Does the Treaty System Work?

The case for: Antarctica has been demilitarised and nuclear-free for more than sixty years; seven overlapping and in places conflicting territorial claims have been frozen without a single armed

confrontation; the mining ban has held through periods of high commodity prices; open inspection is genuinely exercised; and the Ross Sea MPA showed that an area of high-seas ocean the size of Alaska, Texas and California combined can be protected by agreement. Compared with the governance of the atmosphere or of high-seas fisheries, this is a strong record.

The case against: the 29 Consultative Parties decide for a continent that legally belongs to everyone, and the 29 Non-Consultative Parties may attend but not vote — a democratic deficit for a global common. Consensus gives every party a veto, which has blocked three proposed MPAs for years. Enforcement across 14 million km² of land and a vastly larger ocean is thin: IUU fishing persists, and the krill trigger limit in Area 48 was reached for the first time in 2025 precisely where predator colonies feed. Tourism is regulated largely by the industry itself. And the system is powerless against its single biggest threat: no Antarctic instrument can slow warming caused by emissions from outside the region.

The judgement AQA rewards: Antarctic governance is highly effective at managing the threats it was designed for — sovereignty conflict, militarisation, mineral exploitation — and structurally weak against threats that are either external (climate change) or require new collective restraint (fishing, tourism). That distinction, rather than a verdict of "successful" or "unsuccessful", is what a Level 4 answer looks like.

Exam Tip: AQA requires you to consider how global governance "underlies and impacts on students' and other people's lives across the globe". Make that link explicit for Antarctica: Antarctic ice loss drives sea-level rise that reaches UK coastal communities; the Southern Ocean absorbs a disproportionate share of anthropogenic heat and CO₂, moderating the climate everywhere; krill oil supplements and farmed-salmon feed link a British supermarket shelf directly to Area 48; and Antarctic ice cores supply the baseline data on which global climate policy rests.

10. Globalisation Critique

Benefits	Costs
Growth and poverty reduction — the proportion of the world's population living in extreme poverty fell dramatically between 1990 and	Rising inequality <i>within</i> many countries, even where inequality between countries narrowed; deindustrialised regions in HICs lost secure employment and have not recovered

2019, driven largely by export-led growth in China and East Asia	
Access to cheaper goods, wider choice and technology transfer; mobile phones and internet access spread faster than any previous technology	Race to the bottom — competition for investment can push down wages, labour standards and environmental protection; sweatshop conditions and the 2013 Rana Plaza collapse in Bangladesh, which killed over 1,100 garment workers
Integration and stability — economically interdependent states have strong incentives to avoid conflict, and shared institutions provide a forum for resolving disputes	Vulnerability through interdependence — a shock in one node propagates globally, as the 2008 financial crisis, the COVID-19 supply shock and chokepoint disruption at Suez and Panama all demonstrated
Cultural exchange, diaspora networks, global civil society and the rapid international spread of ideas and campaigns	Cultural erosion and homogenisation; dominance of a few languages and media conglomerates; loss of local distinctiveness and, in some places, backlash and resurgent nationalism
Global cooperation on shared problems — the Montreal Protocol on ozone-depleting substances is the most successful environmental treaty ever agreed	Environmental cost — emissions embedded in long supply chains, deforestation driven by export commodities, and the export of waste from rich to poorer countries

Exam Tip: Deglobalisation is now a defensible line of argument and few candidates take it. Since 2018 tariffs have risen, export controls on strategic technology have multiplied, supply chains have been reshored or friend-shored, and the WTO's appellate function has been paralysed — yet trade values keep hitting records. The strongest conclusion is usually that globalisation is being *reorganised* along geopolitical lines rather than reversed. Say that, support it with two dated pieces of evidence, and you are writing at the top band.

Exam Tip: Paper 2 Section A carries 6-, 9- and 20-mark questions. The 20-mark ones almost always contain an evaluative hinge — "to what extent", "assess the view that". Plan three paragraphs with a named example in each, decide your line of argument *before* you start writing, and return to it explicitly in the conclusion. Use Antarctica as your default worked example for governance questions

and Apple or cocoa for trade questions; having two well-rehearsed cases beats having eight half-remembered ones.